SESSION 11

The Case You Wrote

Design Thinking for MBAs

Wednesday, February 25, 2026 | Instructor: Patrick Ray

The Complete Analytical Process

Phase	What Happens	Where It's Taught
1. Primary Research	Ethnographic observation, stakeholder interviews, contextual inquiry	This course
2. Systems Modeling	Mapping dynamics, feedback loops, root causes	This course
3. Problem Definition	Bounding the problem, framing it precisely, making it actionable	This course
4. Framework Application	Porter's, SWOT, financial models, decision matrices	Your other courses
5. Recommendation	Strategic options, implementation plan, stakeholder management	Your other courses

Most of your courses start at phase 4. This course teaches phases 1 through 3.

Before You Opened the Packet

Think about a case you've all analyzed.

Who are the most important stakeholders in that case?

Which of those stakeholders did the case author actually interview?

Do you know?

Before You Opened the Packet

What would you learn about that stakeholder if you spent **90 minutes observing them** instead of reading a two-paragraph description in the case?

Before You Opened the Packet

Who decided that was the problem?

What if the real problem is something the case author didn't see because they didn't talk to the right people?

Before You Opened the Packet

Your framework is rigorous. But it can only analyze the data it's given.

What if the data is incomplete?

> *The framework gives you a rigorous answer to the wrong question. And the framework can't tell you that's happened.*

Today's Session

Phase	What You Do
Prep	Identify the 5 critical assumptions in your analysis. Which ones would change your entire recommendation if wrong?
Discussion	Teams pair up. Brief the other team on your case. They find the weakest point. Switch.
Synthesis	Full class. What did the discussions reveal?
Prototyping	What to build and test before Monday.

Prep: What Are You Assuming?

Team Activity

1. List at least **5 assumptions** your recommendation depends on
2. Categorize each: **Desirability, Feasibility, or Viability**
3. Rank: if wrong, does everything collapse or just a piece?
4. Your **top 2**: the ones where everything falls apart
5. For those top 2: what observable evidence would prove you wrong?

~10 minutes

Desirability

Do stakeholders actually want this? Will they change behavior?

Feasibility

Can this work in the real context? Do the resources exist?

Viability

Should an organization invest in this? Is it sustainable?

Discussion: Pressure Test

Paired Teams

1. **Team A briefs their case**: problem, recommendation, two critical assumptions. Conversational, not a presentation. (3 min)
2. **Team B interrogates.** Challenge assumptions. Push on evidence. (8-9 min)
3. **Switch roles.**

~25 minutes total

Questions worth asking:

- "What evidence do you have beyond your own intuition?"
- "You interviewed [N] stakeholders. How do you know that's representative?"
- "What if [alternative dynamic] is actually driving this?"
- "Why should I believe the problem is what you say it is?"
- "What evidence would make you walk away from this recommendation?"

What Did the Discussion Reveal?

- What assumption did the other team find that **you didn't list**?
- Based on what you just heard, what are you **changing before Monday**?

> *You wrote the case instead of reading it. The next time you read a Harvard case, you'll read it differently.*

Three Tools, One Company

Before Monday, you need to build a prototype. Here's what that means, and what it doesn't.

MVP

Built to Run

A product you ship and keep running. It's rough, but it works as a service. You grow it into a business.

SURVIVAL TACTIC

Built to Not Die

Pure scrappiness. Whatever it takes to keep the lights on and prove you won't quit.

PROTOTYPE

Built to Learn

Tests one assumption with one real person. Might be disposable. Not built to last. Built to find out if you're right.

You're building a prototype. Not an MVP. Not a business. A test.

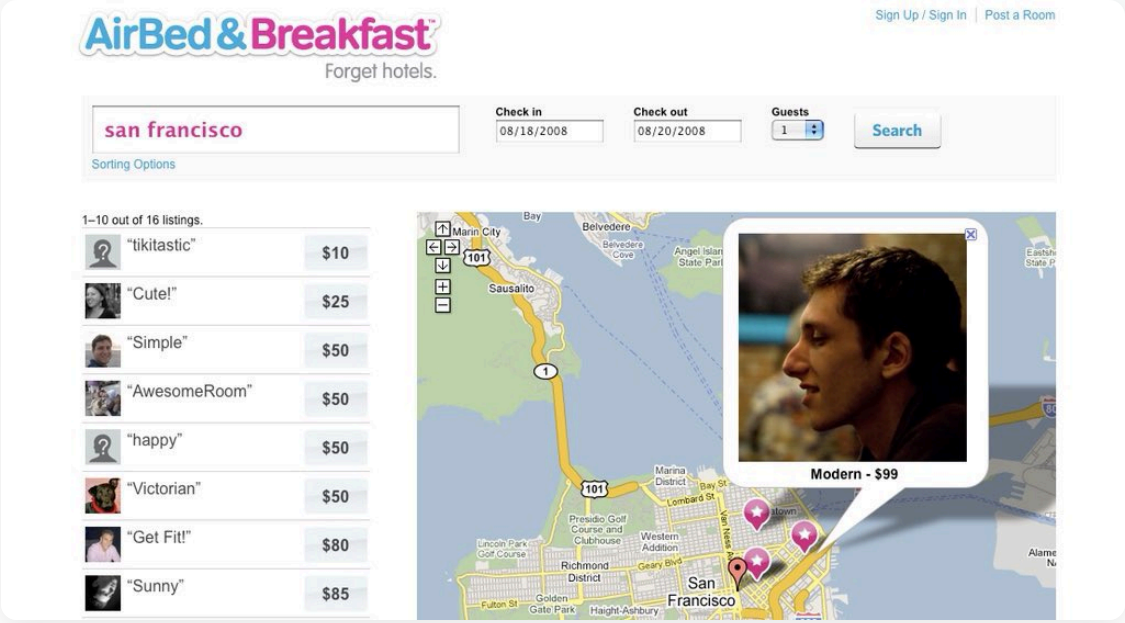
The MVP: Air Mattresses, 2007

MVP

Chesky and Gebbia can't make rent. Design conference in SF, hotels sold out. They buy three air mattresses, build a simple website: AirBed and Breakfast. $80/night. Breakfast included. Three strangers show up and pay.

They kept running it. Kept hosting.

It became the business.



The Survival Tactic: Cereal Boxes, 2008

SURVIVAL

One year later. Airbnb is nearly dead. No funding, no traction, massive debt. The 2008 election is happening.
They design custom cereal: Obama O's and Cap'n McCains. 500 boxes each. $20 to make, $40 to sell. They sell out. $30,000. Enough to keep the lights on.

> **Paul Graham, Y Combinator:**
> "If you can convince people to pay $40 for a $4 box of cereal, you can convince people to stay in each other's homes. You are cockroaches. You will not die."

The Problem: Would You Book This?

The Prototype: Photography, 2009

PROTOTYPE

Airbnb has users, but nobody's booking. Hypothesis: the photos are terrible and that's killing trust.
They rent a camera, fly to New York, knock on hosts' doors. One week. One apartment at a time.

2-3x more bookings.

Revenue doubled that month.

Then they threw away the prototype and built the real program.

"A web startup would say, 'Let's send emails, teach users professional photography, and test them.' We said, 'Screw that.'"

They rented a $5,000 camera and snapped high-resolution photos of as many New York host apartments as they could. Bookings soared. By month's end, revenue had doubled.

"When we fixed the product in New York, it solved our problems in Paris, London, Vancouver, and Miami."

Chesky & Gebbia, Fast Company

Studio Time: Plan Your Prototype

Team Activity: Answer three questions. Write them down.

1. **Which assumption are you testing?**
   Pick your riskiest one from the case discussion.
2. **What's the smallest thing you can build to test it?**
   Not the whole solution. Just the test.
3. **Who will you test it with, and when?**
   Name a real person. Pick a day before Monday.

~15 minutes

A paper mockup. A role-played service encounter. A structured conversation. A one-page document in front of a decision-maker. It can be rough. A real person has to interact with it.

What You Practiced Today

Synthesize Information

Surfacing the assumptions buried in your own analysis. Separating evidence from conviction.

Learn From Others

Using adversarial questioning to find what you couldn't see from inside your own case.

Experiment Rapidly

Designing a prototype that tests your riskiest assumption with a real person before Monday.

Build and Craft Intentionally

Choosing the right fidelity for the right moment. Built to learn, not built to last.

Monday: Tell the Story of Your Project

- **9-minute block** per team. Format is your choice.
- **Three-act structure:** The world as it is, what you learned, what you built and what happened when real people used it.
- **Prototype required:** Build and test something with at least one real stakeholder before Monday.
- **Audience involvement:** Meaningful, not token.

Deadlines:

- **Saturday by 2:15 PM:** Format rationale via email
- **Monday in class:** Present. Bring physical notebooks. Digital notebooks on Canvas by end of day.

Find the Duct Tape: Last one before Monday. Identify and document one workaround or improvised fix in your notebook.